Financial Trade Data

Seven full years: 2018 - 2024 | U.S. and world trade in goods and services, in nominal U.S. dollars

This document adds a 4-8 year financial trade history to the AI data center document set. Every figure is a real published total from the U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis (BEA) or the World Trade Organization (WTO). Nothing is estimated, forecast, or simulated. Full source links are on the last page.

$7,301.6bn
U.S. total trade in 2024 - exports plus imports of goods and services

-$918.4bn
U.S. goods and services balance in 2024

$24.43tn
World merchandise exports in 2024

What the seven years show

- **Trade grew over the period.** U.S. exports rose 27.6% from $2,501.3 billion in 2018 to $3,191.6 billion in 2024, and imports rose 31.4% from $3,129.0 billion to $4,110.0 billion.
- **2020 was the break.** U.S. exports fell to $2,131.9 billion and world merchandise exports fell to $17,648 billion as the pandemic cut travel, transport, and goods demand.
- **The deficit was widest in 2022** at $948.1 billion, narrowed in 2023, and widened again in 2024.
- **Services stayed in surplus every year.** The U.S. services surplus reached $293.3 billion in 2024, partly offsetting a goods deficit of $1,211.7 billion.

How this document is organized

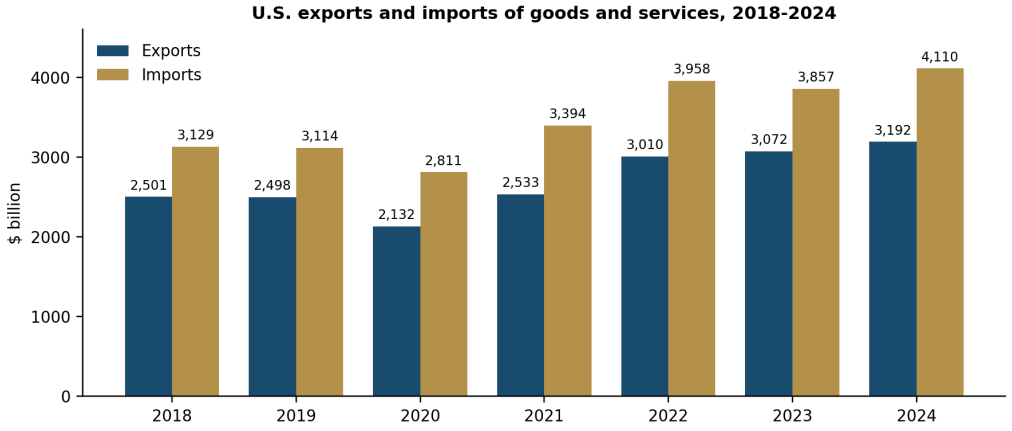
Page 2: the full U.S. table and chart. Page 3: the goods deficit versus the services surplus. Page 4: world merchandise trade. Page 5: what moved each year, including the capital-goods trade that supplies data centers. Page 6: how to use the data, its limits, and sources.

Reading note: figures are nominal (not adjusted for inflation). BEA revises prior years when it publishes a new annual release, so a total here may differ by a few billion dollars from the first release for that year. Totals may not sum exactly due to rounding.

U.S. trade in goods and services, 2018-2024

The United States exported more and imported more at the end of the period than at the start. Total trade - exports plus imports - rose from $5,630.3 billion in 2018 to $7,301.6 billion in 2024.

Year	Exports ($bn)	Imports ($bn)	Balance ($bn)	Deficit as % of GDP
2018	2,501.3	3,129.0	-627.7	3.0%
2019	2,498.0	3,114.5	-616.4	2.9%
2020	2,131.9	2,810.6	-678.7	3.2%
2021	2,533.0	3,394.3	-861.4	3.7%
2022	3,009.7	3,957.8	-948.1	3.7%
2023	3,071.8	3,856.7	-784.9	2.8%
2024	3,191.6	4,110.0	-918.4	3.1%



Reading the table

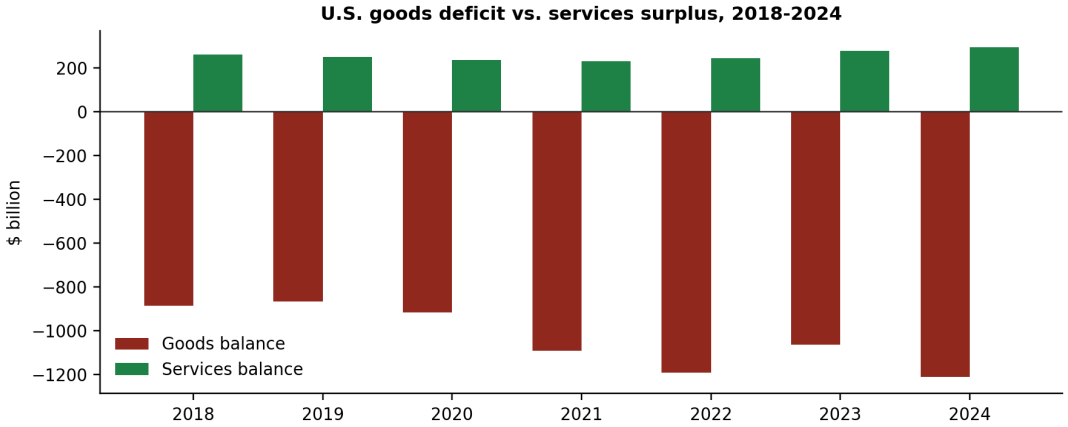
- **2019 was flat.** Exports eased $3.3 billion to $2,498.0 billion and imports eased $14.5 billion, so the deficit narrowed slightly to $616.4 billion.
- **2021-2022 was the surge.** Exports jumped to $3,009.7 billion and imports to $3,957.8 billion by 2022, and the deficit reached its widest point in this period.
- **2023 was the pullback.** Imports fell $101.1 billion on the revised figures and the deficit narrowed to $784.9 billion, 2.8% of GDP.
- **2024 widened again.** Imports rose $253.3 billion against a $119.8 billion rise in exports, taking the deficit to $918.4 billion, 3.1% of GDP.

Source: BEA, U.S. International Trade in Goods and Services, annual releases for 2018-2024. The 2023 figures are the revised totals published with the 2024 release.

The goods deficit drove the total every year

In all seven years the United States ran a large deficit in goods and a smaller surplus in services. The headline balance is the sum of the two, so any plan that depends on imported equipment is exposed to the goods side, and any plan that sells services abroad sits on the surplus side.

Year	Goods balance ($bn)	Services balance ($bn)	Total balance ($bn)
2018	-887.3	259.7	-627.7
2019	-866.2	249.8	-616.4
2020	-915.8	237.1	-678.7
2021	-1,091.4	230.0	-861.4
2022	-1,191.8	243.7	-948.1
2023	-1,063.3	278.4	-784.9
2024	-1,211.7	293.3	-918.4



What changed inside services

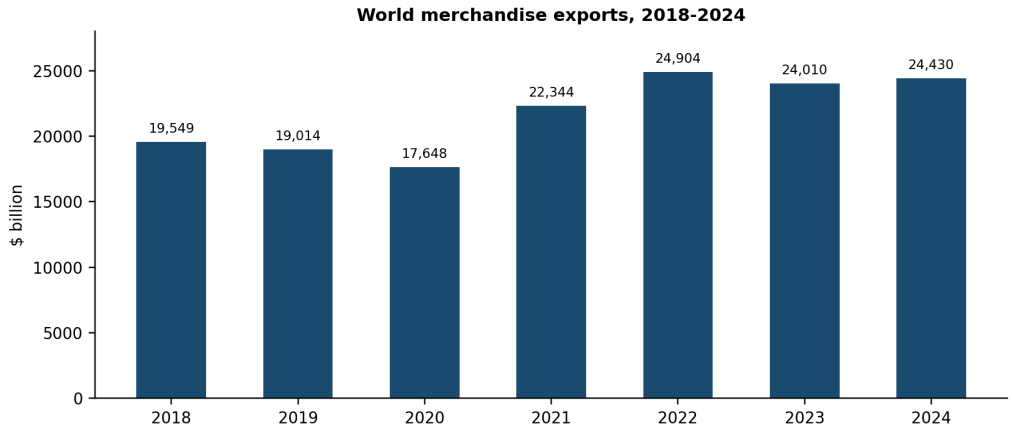
- In 2023, U.S. exports of services rose $74.2 billion to $1,002.8 billion. Travel rose $38.3 billion, financial services rose $7.4 billion, transport rose $7.3 billion, and telecommunications, computer, and information services rose $7.1 billion.
- In 2024, exports of services rose a further $81.2 billion to $1,107.8 billion. Travel rose $26.3 billion, other business services rose $16.0 billion, and telecommunications, computer, and information services rose $11.9 billion.
- The services surplus grew from $230.0 billion in 2021 to $293.3 billion in 2024, even as the goods deficit also grew - the two sides do not move together.

Source: BEA annual trade releases, 2018-2024. Goods and services components may not sum exactly to the total due to rounding and revision vintage.

World merchandise trade, 2018-2024

World merchandise exports follow the same story as U.S. trade, at a larger scale: a pandemic fall in 2020, a sharp rebound in 2021-2022, a fall in value in 2023 as commodity prices eased, and a recovery in 2024. Over the full period, world merchandise exports rose 25.0%, from $19,549 billion in 2018 to $24,430 billion in 2024.

Year	World merchandise exports ($bn)	Year	World merchandise exports ($bn)
2018	19,549	2019	19,014
2020	17,648	2021	22,344
2022	24,905	2023	24,010
2024	24,430		



Points that matter for planning

- **2023 fell in value, not only in volume.** The WTO reported merchandise trade fell 5% in value in 2023 to $24.01 trillion, while commercial services trade rose 9% to $7.54 trillion, so total goods and services trade was down only about 2%.
- **2024 recovered.** The WTO reported world merchandise exports rose 2% to $24.43 trillion in 2024, and commercial services exports rose to $8.69 trillion.
- **The largest traders in 2024** were China, the largest merchandise exporter at $3.58 trillion, and the United States, the largest merchandise importer at $3.36 trillion, according to the WTO Annual Report for 2025.

Source: WTO, World Trade Statistical Review 2023, Table A56 for 2018-2022; WTO Global Trade Outlook, April 2024, for 2023; WTO Annual Report 2025, as reported, for 2024.

What moved each year

2018-2019 - Flat trade, slightly narrower U.S. deficit

The U.S. deficit eased from $627.7 billion in 2018 to $616.4 billion in 2019. Exports of U.S. services rose, led by other business services and by telecommunications, computer, and information services, while exports and imports of goods both fell.

2020 - Pandemic fall

U.S. exports fell $396.4 billion on the revised 2019 base published with the 2020 release, with capital goods down $87.5 billion, including civilian aircraft and aircraft engines. The services surplus shrank as travel collapsed, and the total deficit widened to $678.7 billion even though imports also fell.

2021-2022 - Rebound and import surge

U.S. exports of goods and services rose to $2,533.0 billion in 2021 and $3,009.7 billion in 2022. Imports rose faster, driven by industrial supplies, consumer goods, and capital goods, and the deficit reached $861.4 billion in 2021 and $948.1 billion in 2022.

2023 - Goods pullback, services growth

U.S. exports of goods fell $39.2 billion, led by industrial supplies and materials, while exports of services rose $74.2 billion, led by travel. Imports of goods fell $160.5 billion, and the deficit narrowed by $177.8 billion in the original 2023 release.

2024 - Capital goods led the growth

U.S. exports of goods rose $38.6 billion to $2,083.8 billion. Capital goods rose $40.2 billion, including computer accessories (up $11.3 billion), computers (up $8.2 billion), and semiconductors (up $8.1 billion). Imports of goods rose on capital goods, mainly computer accessories and computers, and on consumer goods, mainly pharmaceutical products.

Why this matters for an AI data center business

- Servers, computer accessories, and semiconductors are traded capital goods. Their import and export values move with data center building cycles, so the 2024 capital-goods rise is the trade footprint of AI build-out.
- Imported equipment costs follow the goods side of trade, where the U.S. deficit is largest and prices are most exposed to tariffs and exchange rates.
- Services - including telecommunications, computer, and information services - are a U.S. export strength, which is the side a data center operator sells on.

How to use this data - and its limits

Use it for

- **Market context:** sizing demand and checking whether a year was a growth year or a pullback before quoting a price or signing a supply contract.
- **Supply planning:** watching capital-goods imports - computers, computer accessories, and semiconductors - as an early signal of equipment demand and lead-time pressure.
- **Finance conversations:** giving a lender or partner a sourced, dated trade history instead of an unsourced market claim.

Limits to keep in view

- All figures are **nominal**: they include price changes, so a rise in value is not the same as a rise in volume. The WTO reported world merchandise trade volume fell 1.2% in 2023 while value fell 5%.
- **BEA revises its figures.** Check the current BEA release before filing, investing, or quoting a total in a contract.
- This document covers **2018-2024, the last seven complete years** in the sources used. It does not include a full-year 2025 total, and it contains no forecast.
- Trade totals describe whole economies. They do not describe any one company, shipment, or contract.

Verify before you file or invest

- Re-check the U.S. totals in the latest BEA annual release and the world totals in the latest WTO Global Trade Outlook or Annual Report. Keep the release date with any figure you copy into a business plan or loan file.

Sources

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